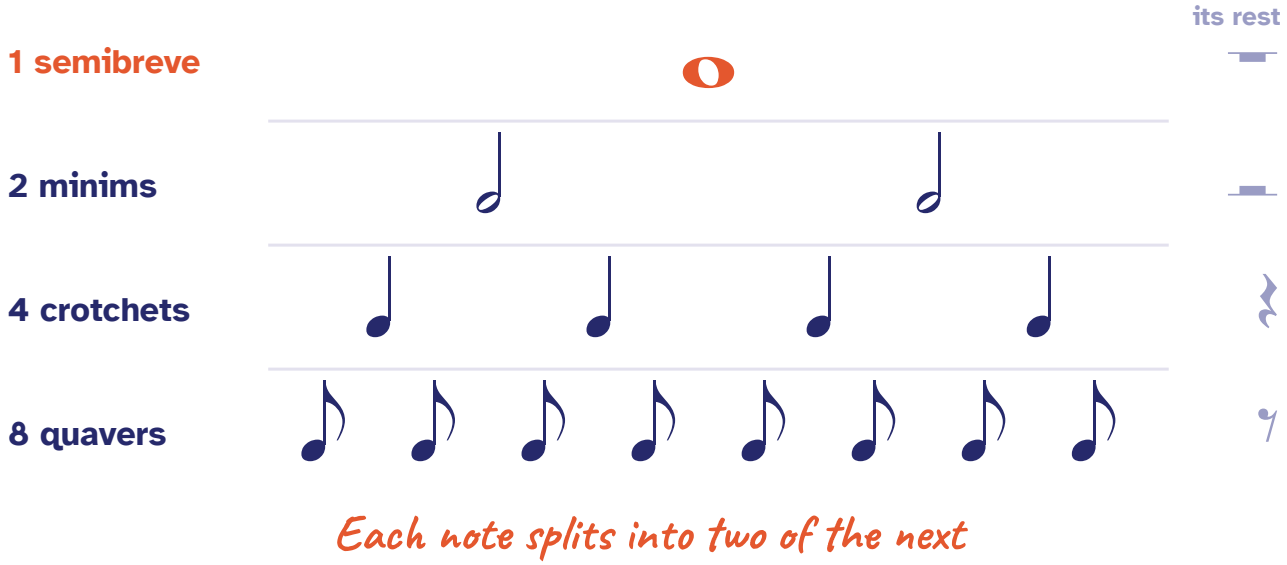
PART II · TIME · 2

Notes and rests

You can see how long a note lasts from its shape: each plain note is **half** the one above it. And every note has a twin **rest**, a silence you count just as carefully.

THE SECRET

Each note is half the one above it, and every note has a rest twin.

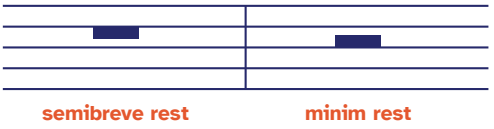


Each note splits into two of the next

Head, stem, flag

The **head** sits on a line or in a space. A **stem** goes up on the right of the head or down on the left. **Flags** on the stem halve the value each time; groups of quavers are joined by **beams** instead of flags.

Which rest is which?



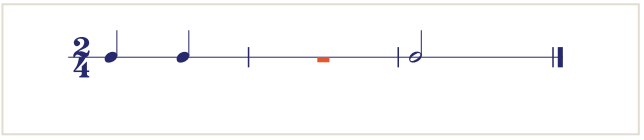
The semibreve rest **hangs** below the fourth line; the minim rest **sits** on the middle line.

THE SEMIBREVE REST'S SPECIAL POWER

Most rests last a fixed number of beats. The **semibreve rest** can also mean **a whole bar of silence** in any time signature: 4 beats in 4/4, but 3 in 3/4 and 2 in 2/4. It is then centred in the bar. No other rest can do this.

One more rule: keep the middle of a 4/4 bar visible. Silence on beats 2–3 is two crotchet rests, never one minim rest.





* With the crotchet as one beat, as in 2/4, 3/4 and 4/4. *Extra*: beyond Level 8.

PART II · TIME · 2 · CONTINUED

NOTE	REST	NAME	ALSO CALLED	BEATS*	FIRST MET
		**breve**	double whole note	**8**	Level 4
		**dotted semibreve**	dotted whole note	**6**	*Extra*
		**semibreve**	whole note	**4**	Level 0
		**dotted minim**	dotted half note	**3**	Level 0
		**minim**	half note	**2**	Level 0
		**dotted crotchet**	dotted quarter note	**1½**	Level ½
		**crotchet**	quarter note	**1**	Level 0
		**dotted quaver**	dotted eighth note	**¾**	Level 3
		**quaver**	eighth note	**½**	Level 0
		**semiquaver**	sixteenth note	**¼**	Level 2
		**demisemiquaver**	32nd note	**⅛**	*Extra*
		**hemidemisemiquaver**	64th note	**1/16**	*Extra*

PART II · TIME · 2 · CONTINUED

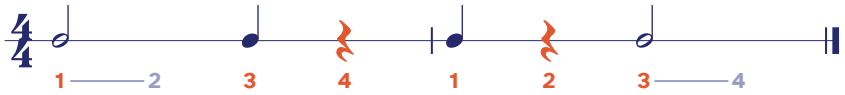
Why whole, half and quarter?

Think of each beat as a pizza. A bar of 4/4 is four pizzas. The note that fills the whole bar is the **whole note**; the others are a half, a quarter, an eighth and a sixteenth of it. Two quavers beamed together fill one pizza. A rest is the same share left empty: shaded with lines.

semibreve	whole note	4 pizzas · 4 beats	
semibreve rest	silence	4 empty pizzas · 4 beats	
minim	half note	2 pizzas · 2 beats	
minim rest	silence	2 empty pizzas · 2 beats	
crotchet	quarter note	1 pizza · 1 beat	
crotchet rest	silence	1 empty pizza · 1 beat	
quaver	eighth note	half a pizza · ½ beat	
quaver rest	silence	half an empty pizza · ½ beat	
semiquaver	sixteenth note	a quarter of a pizza · ¼ beat	
semiquaver rest	silence	a quarter of an empty pizza · ¼ beat	

EXAMPLE 1

How long is each sound, and each silence?

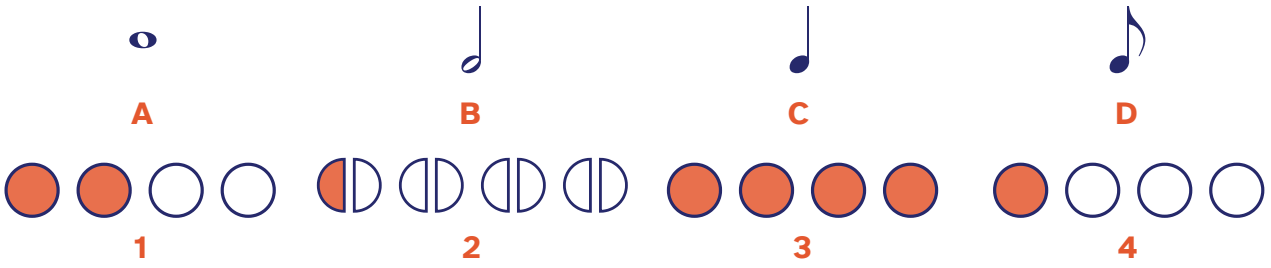


1. **Name each shape:** minim, crotchet, crotchet rest.
2. **Count its beats:** 2, 1 and 1.
3. **Count the rests too:** the red rests last as long as their notes.

Every bar adds up to **4 beats**, silences included.

GAME

Pizza match



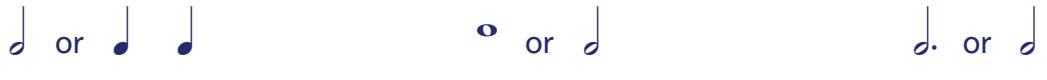
Match each note (A to D) with its pizzas (1 to 4). One pizza is one beat.

Answer: A 3, B 1, C 4, D 2.

PART II · TIME · 2 · CONTINUED

GAME

Which lasts longer?



1 2 3

Circle the longer side in each pair. One pair is a trick: both sides are the same length.

Answer: 1 the same (2 beats each), 2 the semibreve (4 beats), 3 the dotted minim (3 beats).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

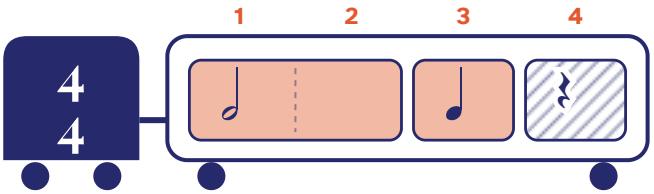


Clap once and hold for 2: a minim.

Now clap four crotchets (1 2 3 4), then one semibreve (clap, and hold all four beats). Say the counts out loud.

EXAMPLE 2

Fill a bar of 4/4



1. **The minim** takes two seats: beats 1 and 2.
2. **The crotchet** takes one: beat 3.
3. **One seat is left:** a crotchet rest, counted like a note.

Minim + crotchet + crotchet rest = **4 beats**: the bar is full.

HOW TO

Learn the note shapes

1. **Hollow or filled:** hollow heads last longer (semibreve, minim).
2. **Stem or no stem:** the semibreve has none.
3. **Count the flags:** each one halves the note again.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



Six **crotchets**, then a **minim** at the end of the line: one beat, one beat … and two beats to breathe.

Try it. Clap the line and say “1 1 1 1 1 1 1-2”.

SEE ALSO
Pulse and the bar p. 39 · How long is a note? p. 46

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · Note values · Online: Library › Notes